ASSOCIATION COMMUNAUTAIRE
CENTRETOWN
COMMUNITY ASSOCIATION

210 Gloucester Street, Suite 101
Ottawa, Ontario K2P 2K4

Tuesday, November 12, 2024

Mr. Joe Mojsej
City Project Manager
Senior Engineer, Infrastructure Services
Design and Construction – Municipal
100 Constellation Drive, Ottawa, ON K2G 6J8
joe.mojsej@ottawa.ca

RE: James Street & Kent Street – Integrated Sewer, Watermain and Road Renewal

Dear Mr. Mojsej,

The Trees and Greenspace Committee of the Centretown Community Association is writing to you concerning the current infrastructure renewal project proposed for James Street. We have serious concerns about the loss of mature canopy trees that is currently part of the proposal.

A working group of the Committee, Centretown NeighbourWoods, has for several years worked to protect and enhance Centretown's tree canopy, which is the lowest in the City of Ottawa. In fact, they have documented an approximate 24% decrease in trees in the City right of way over the past few years, including along James Street. We are, therefore, dismayed to find out that the current proposal involves the destruction of many of the remaining mature and valued shade trees.

While we acknowledge the necessity for infrastructure renewal, we do not believe that it should happen without every effort being made to maintain Ottawa's valuable green infrastructure. These mature trees provide important services by attenuating heat in our increasingly hot summers and by filtering out air pollution. Ottawa Public Health's recent report specifically mentions both of these health risks and refers to the interconnection between health and nature. The City's efforts to mitigate the impacts of climate change should include all assets, both natural and built infrastructure.

Although the James Street proposal calls for the planting of replacement trees, it will take decades for young trees to reach the size and maturity to provide the health and climate resiliency benefits needed in the near future. Moreover, we fear that the replacement species chosen will not be of the size of the trees destroyed under the current plan. James Street has already lost several large trees to severe pruning when Hydro Ottawa lowered the wires a few years ago. Having more large trees destroyed under the current proposal would further negatively affect the neighbourhood character.

We have noted that others have written with suggestions that would help save the current trees and support their consideration. They include:

1. Re-routing pipes or boring under roots where trench excavation for new water pipes toward the houses is too close to the trunks.

2. Notching the sidewalks where trunks are too close to the new sidewalk edge, similar to the notch proposed at 188-190 James.

3. Using the opportunity of street renewal to plant more trees. This is a perfect opportunity to proactively work with residents to plant more trees in the City Right of Way. Over 20 potential front yards with sufficient soil area to support a tree have been identified, in addition to those proposed in the James Street plan. Furthermore, there is the possibility of planting additional trees along a commercial building west of Bank Street, using underground soil supports such as Silva Cells.

The James Street infrastructure project is an opportunity to be innovative by designing infrastructure renewal that can also retain and improve the tree canopy and its many benefits. We ask that you consider the proposed alternatives to destroying the James Street trees.

Yours truly,

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